Mobile Phones

Presented by:

Mobile Phones

Introduction

- How many mobile phones are in use
- What are their effects on driving?
- How does this change the risk of having an accident?
- What is the law

Mobile Phone Use

2000 - 25 million mobile phone users

2005 - 45 million mobile phone users

Whilst driving –

- 2.5% of car drivers were using a mobile phone in a survey conducted in April 2006
  - One in every 40!

- Higher for drivers of other vehicles - 3.5%

Effects in Driving Simulations

Drivers using a mobile phone

- Take longer to respond to hazards and more likely not to respond – especially older subjects.
- Have large deviations in lane position
- Miss traffic signals.
- Do not maintain a steady speed, and tend to follow the vehicle in font much more closely

As bad, or worse, than legal drink drive level.

Effects in Off Road Track Studies

Drivers using a mobile phone

- Even on an empty, wide runway, drivers veered out of their ‘lane’.
- Reactions to pop-up targets slower, and drivers swerved round them at higher speed. Also took riskier decision when joining traffic stream.
- Increased braking times and poor lane position. Drivers took eyes off road for up to 2 seconds & tended to stare ahead when using phone.

Effects in On Road Studies

Drivers using a mobile phone

- Delayed response times and slower reaction to brake lights. Mental workload increased.
- Increased stress and frustration.
- Visual attention divided between phone and road. Inexperienced drivers took eyes off road for more than 2.5 seconds.
- In normal motorway traffic, drivers response times to vehicle ahead decelerating were slower and time to collision was reduced by about 1 second.

The Risk of Crashing

Large number of studies

- USA study – crash risk 4 times higher when using hand-held or hands-free mobile phone.
- USA study – drivers using mobile phone 9 times more likely to be in fatal accident. More likely to cause the accident, hit a pedestrian or overturn their vehicle.
- UK Study – drivers using hand held and hands free phones took longer to react to a hazard than drivers impaired by alcohol.

Casualty Figures

Using Mobile Phones

- Before 2005 RoSPA collected media reports of accidents which resulted in a fatality
  - 23 reported fatalities collected
  - Wide range of incidents in which drivers were checking voice mails, as well as dialling and speaking on the phone.
- 2005 first yearly casualty figures published
  - 13 fatalities
  - 52 accidents resulting in a serious injury
- Doesn't include hands free accidents, or where police could not establish phone use

The Law

Since 1st December 2003

- Offence to use hand-held mobile phone while driving
- Includes any electronic device to access oral, text or pictorial information, inc internet & text messages.
- "Driving" includes engine on while vehicle is stationary. Includes motorcycles, not bicycles.
  - Excludes 2-way "press to talk" radios
  - Excludes emergency call to 999 if unsafe to stop
  - Excludes Hands-free

Conclusions

1. Massive increase in using a mobile phone while driving
2. Strong evidence that using mobile phone significantly impairs driving
3. Strong evidence that this increases risk of crashing
4. Evidence of people killed by drivers using mobile phones
5. Education & publicity failed to stop drivers using mobiles

Conclusions

6. New law from February 2007 increased penalty for using a hand held phone to 3 points and £60 fine
7. Includes an offence of “cause or permit” a driver to use a hand-held phone while driving
8. Other laws on Dangerous and Careless driving can be applied against use of hands-free phones

Conclusions

9. Employers need to address this within their MORR policies. Employers that require staff to use hand held mobile phones while driving can be held responsible under corporate manslaughter law if it results in a collision and death.